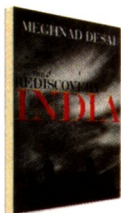


Where History is BUNK

An economist's belated tryst with the Indian story produces a book of amusement



**THE REDISCOVERY
OF INDIA**

by MEGHNAD DESAI

Allen Lane

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By Chandan Mitra

It is perhaps understandable if in his late 30s Rahul Gandhi seeks to rediscover the India that his great-grandfather "discovered" in the 1930s, but Lord Meghnad Desai's attempt to fashion himself as Jawaharlal Nehru's 21st century avatar is not only bewildering but also presumptuous. The author has neither Nehru's depth of understanding, nor his sense of history and certainly does not possess the linguistic finesse that made the writings of India's first prime minister so eminently readable.

After plodding through 500 pages of laboured text, it is difficult to fathom the purpose of the author. Desai says it took him between July 2007 and December 2008, a good 18 months, to write this tome. I would have thought before embarking on the project, he would have asked himself why he wanted to write this book in the first place. But that query evidently eluded him and, therefore, the answer is bound to elude the reader. Since the learned professor of economics appears to have read history texts only now, he may have felt it to be his bounden duty to pass on his reading to the rest of us. By virtue of his exalted title, the book may find initial buyers too. As to its academic worth, the judgement must be left to readers, but it is unlikely to be complimentary to the affable Professor Emeritus of the London School of Economics. In terms of time-pass value, it scores very low indeed.

What has been promoted as a unique feature of the book, something called Counterfactual Box, enables the author to indulge in some implausible flights of fancy. Sample this in the chapter titled The Vasco Da Gama Moment: speculating what could have happened to India had the English not won certain decisive battles with rival colonial powers, Desai writes, "Tamil Nadu could have been French-speaking and Bengal either Dutch or English-speaking. Maharashtra may have been Portuguese-speaking, Gujarat English-speaking and so on. There would have been many nation states (or perhaps kingdoms) in the Doab and the Punjab..." The writer does not appear to have heard of the dictum that it is meaningless to speculate over the "ifs and buts" of history. I fail to see how such stray thoughts add to our



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understanding either of colonialism or Indian history. Besides, nearly 200 years after British rule, Tamil Nadu speaks Tamil, Bengal Bengali, Maharashtra Marathi and Gujarat Gujarati. Even in Goa, hardly anybody speaks Portuguese today.

As long as the author sticks to a routine narrative of events, the volume can be benignly regarded as an attempted précis of hitherto written textbooks. But whenever Desai attempts to insert his own interpretations, the paucity of understanding of the complexity of the multi-layered Hindu consciousness comes through quite appallingly. He blithely comments: "There were also historical divisions between regions and peoples. Thus Maratha depredations were resentfully recalled in Bengal and Gujarat. The great epic Ramayana was denigrated in the South as a story of Northern conquest of Southern peoples. The river Indus was perceived as a boundary beyond which a Hindu suffered pollution and loss of caste." To most Indians, all this